Preventive Healthcare and Wellness
Vaccinations and Immunizations
Vaccines are one of the most effective ways to prevent infectious diseases. They work by training the immune system to recognize and fight specific pathogens.
Recommended Adult Vaccinations
- **Influenza (Flu)**: Annually, especially for those over 65, pregnant women, and people with chronic conditions
- **COVID-19**: Follow current CDC/WHO recommendations for boosters
- **Tdap/Td**: Tetanus, diphtheria, and pertussis booster every 10 years
- **Pneumococcal**: Recommended for adults 65 and older and those with certain health conditions
- **Shingles (Herpes Zoster)**: Recommended for adults 50 and older
- **HPV**: Recommended up to age 26 (may be given up to age 45 in some cases)
- **Hepatitis B**: Recommended for all adults who haven't been vaccinated
Childhood Vaccination Schedule
Children should receive vaccinations as recommended by pediatric healthcare providers, including vaccines for:
- Measles, Mumps, Rubella (MMR)
- Polio
- Diphtheria, Tetanus, Pertussis (DTaP)
- Hepatitis A and B
- Varicella (Chickenpox)
- Haemophilus influenzae type b (Hib)
Source: CDC Immunization Schedule, WHO
Health Screenings
Regular health screenings can detect potential health issues early when they're most treatable.
Recommended Screenings for Adults
- **Blood pressure**: At least once every 2 years (annually if elevated)
- **Cholesterol**: Every 4-6 years for adults 20+, more frequently if at risk
- **Blood glucose/Diabetes**: Every 3 years starting at age 45, earlier if overweight
- **Colorectal cancer**: Starting at age 45 through screening tests
- **Breast cancer (mammogram)**: Discuss timing with healthcare provider, generally starting at age 40-50
- **Cervical cancer (Pap smear)**: Every 3 years for women 21-65
- **Prostate cancer**: Discuss with healthcare provider starting at age 50
- **Skin cancer**: Regular self-examinations and annual dermatologist visits
- **Eye exam**: Every 1-2 years, more frequently for those with diabetes or vision problems
- **Dental check-up**: Every 6-12 months
Source: U.S. Preventive Services Task Force (USPSTF), American Cancer Society
Hygiene Practices
Good hygiene is fundamental to preventing the spread of infections and maintaining overall health.
Hand Hygiene
- Wash hands with soap and water for at least 20 seconds
- Key times: before eating, after using the restroom, after coughing/sneezing, after touching public surfaces
- Use alcohol-based hand sanitizer (at least 60% alcohol) when soap isn't available
- Avoid touching face, especially eyes, nose, and mouth with unwashed hands
Respiratory Hygiene
- Cover mouth and nose when coughing or sneezing (use elbow or tissue)
- Dispose of used tissues immediately
- Wear masks in crowded areas during respiratory illness outbreaks
- Maintain good ventilation in indoor spaces
Food Safety
- Wash hands before handling food
- Cook meats to proper internal temperatures
- Refrigerate perishable foods within 2 hours
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly
- Avoid cross-contamination between raw and cooked foods

Source: WHO, CDC

Mental Health and Stress Management

Mental health is as important as physical health. Chronic stress can weaken the immune system and contribute to various health conditions.

Signs of Stress

- Difficulty sleeping or sleeping too much
- Changes in appetite
- Difficulty concentrating
- Irritability or mood swings
- Physical symptoms: headaches, muscle tension, stomach problems
- Withdrawal from social activities

Stress Management Techniques

- **Deep breathing exercises**: Inhale for 4 counts, hold for 7, exhale for 8
- **Regular physical activity**: At least 30 minutes most days
- **Mindfulness and meditation**: Even 10 minutes daily can reduce stress
- **Adequate sleep**: Aim for 7-9 hours per night
- **Social connections**: Maintain relationships with friends and family
- **Time management**: Prioritize tasks and set realistic goals
- **Limit screen time**: Take breaks from digital devices
- **Seek professional help**: Don't hesitate to talk to a mental health professional

When to Seek Professional Mental Health Support

- Persistent feelings of sadness or hopelessness lasting more than 2 weeks
- Severe anxiety that interferes with daily activities
- Thoughts of self-harm or suicide (seek immediate help: call 988 or 112)
- Substance abuse
- Significant changes in eating or sleeping patterns
- Inability to cope with daily responsibilities

Source: National Institute of Mental Health (NIMH), WHO

Sleep Hygiene

Quality sleep is essential for physical health, mental clarity, and immune function.

Recommended Sleep Duration

- Adults (18-64): 7-9 hours per night
- Older adults (65+): 7-8 hours per night
- Teenagers (13-17): 8-10 hours per night

Tips for Better Sleep

- Maintain a consistent sleep schedule (same bedtime and wake time)
- Create a dark, quiet, cool sleeping environment
- Avoid screens for at least 30-60 minutes before bed
- Limit caffeine after noon
- Avoid large meals close to bedtime
- Exercise regularly, but not within 2-3 hours of bedtime
- Avoid alcohol before bed (it disrupts sleep quality)
- Use relaxation techniques: reading, gentle stretching, warm bath

Source: National Sleep Foundation, CDC